



picturesque HPCA ground. Despite airspace restrictions in northern India, a few Delhi supporters had made the long journey via overnight buses to be part of the occasion.

A passing drizzle just an hour before the toss briefly interrupted proceedings, sending the ground staff scrambling with covers. But the sun returned within minutes. When the drizzle returned 15 minutes before the toss, it persisted, growing heavier and causing a delay of about an hour. Once play resumed under the blanket of a cool mountain night, Punjab got off to a flying start. The wet outfield offered little assistance to the bowlers, and openers Prabhsimran Singh and Priyansh Arya made the most of it. The pair put on a 122-run stand in just 56 deliveries, dismantling both pace and

spin with ease. Arya eventually fell to T. Natarajan, and as captain Shreyas Iyer readied himself to walk out, the situation took a dramatic turn.

One floodlight tower went out. Then another. And another.

Word began to spread across social media of drone attacks in Jammu, Udhampur, and Pathankot — all less than 85 kilometres from the stadium.

Initially, the media contingent stayed put, assuming a routine power disruption. It wasn't until the host broadcaster's crew began packing their equipment — a full 10 minutes later — that the gravity of the situation became clear.

A policeman confirmed the decision to evacuate the stadium, prompting a hurried yet composed exit by journalists, many experiencing

Game off: Fans leaving the Himachal Pradesh Cricket Association Stadium after the IPL 2025 match between Punjab Kings and Delhi Capitals was called off in Dharamsala. R. V. MOORTHY

a crisis of this nature for the first time.

Contrary to what past evacuations might suggest, this one was largely smooth. External security personnel and stadium officials coordinated well, ushering spectators out in a calm and controlled manner. Fans, despite the shock, showed restraint and discipline as they moved to the streets without panic.

The players were also promptly escorted out before the formal announcement that the match had been abandoned.